

Chapter 2

Speaking and acting with care: The grammar of circumspection in Upper Tanana Dene

Olga Lovick

University of Saskatchewan

Upper Tanana Dene has two constructions falling into the domain of circumspection: avertive clause linkings and urgent requests. In avertive linkings, the avertive clause expresses an undesirable consequence that can be averted by the action expressed in the main clause. Somewhat unusual typologically, avertive linkings with a request as main clause are rare in Upper Tanana. I argue in this paper that this is likely due to the fact that requests are generally problematic in Northern Dene, and that spelling out the undesirable consequences to be avoided could suggest to the addressee that their cultural knowledge is inadequate. Instead, there is a dedicated strategy for urgent requests resulting from an insubordinate conditional construction, which draws attention to the undesirable consequences of non-compliance without spelling them out explicitly. Together, these two constructions reflect the circumspect mindset of the Upper Tanana Dene, which requires them to act and speak with care.

1 Introduction

In this paper I describe two constructions falling into the domain of circumspection in Upper Tanana, a Dene (Athabaskan) language spoken in eastern interior Alaska and the western Yukon. *Avertive linkings* are adverbial clause linkings where the subordinate clause expresses an undesirable event that can be averted or prevented by taking the action expressed in the main clause. I choose the label *avertive* over that of *negative purposive*, since in Upper Tanana, this clause



type differs in important ways from negated purposive clauses, as discussed in §2.3. *Urgent requests* are a special type of request signaled by the presence of the marker *dè* ‘if, when.FUT, UR’. This particle suggests that this construction arose via insubordination of a conditional clause construction. Non-compliance with these requests usually has dire consequences, but these are never spelled out explicitly. I will also show how the existence and use of these constructions reflect the circumspect mindset of the Upper Tanana Dene.

In §1.1, I provide cultural background on the Upper Tanana, focusing in particular on the need for circumspect action and careful speaking. §1.2 provides linguistic background on the Upper Tanana language. The avertive clause linking is described in detail in §2, urgent requests in §3. §4 situates both constructions in the cultural context. The findings are summarized in §5.

In my discussion of cultural traits of the Upper Tanana throughout this paper, I draw on ethnographic resources on other Northern Dene groups, in particular on the work by Nelson (1973) on Gwich’in, Nelson et al. (1982) and Nelson (1983) on Koyukon, and Scollon & Scollon (1981) on Tanacross (all these groups are located in Alaska) as well as Rushforth (1985) and Rushforth & Chisholm (1991) on Bearlake (Northwest Territories). The ethnographic literature on Upper Tanana itself focuses on topics that do not relate directly to the focus of the present paper. McKennan (1959) and McKennan (1981) provide broad cultural overviews while McKennan (1969) is concerned with population development during the contact period. The early work by Guéron (1974, 1981) describes the potlatch, one of the most important cultural institutions; her most recent work (Guéron 2005) focuses on the spiritual life and particularly on shamanism.

Even though all of the above cultures differ from each other in many details, the fundamental patterns are very similar, and, as has been argued by McKennan (1981) for the groups known today as Lower, Middle, and Upper Tanana as well as Tanacross, and by Krauss (2000) for Alaskan Dene languages, the group distinctions made by ethnographers and linguists do not reflect the perspective of the Dene themselves, who view their communities as part of an intricate network covering a large portion of North America. In taking this approach, I follow the practice of Scollon & Scollon (1981) in their work on interethnic communication, who focus on two groups they label *Athabaskans* and *speakers of English*. By *Athabaskan*, they “mean anyone who has been socialized to a set of communicative patterns which have their roots in the Athabaskan languages” (p. 12). By the same token, I use the term *Dene* to refer to anyone socialized into any (Northern) Dene culture, while also paying attention to customs specific to the Upper Tanana area.

It is also important to note that many of the cultural traits described here are less salient to younger individuals, likely due to the influence of mainstream American culture.

1.1 The need for circumspection: Careful speaking, careful action

The interactions of Alaskan Dene are characterized by circumspect behaviour, linguistic and non-linguistic. Some aspects of linguistic circumspection have been described by Scollon & Scollon (1981). Of particular importance for our purposes are two points raised there: reluctance to talk about the future (coupled with a need for preparedness) and the principle of non-interference.

For an Alaskan Dene person, to talk with any degree of certainty about the future constitutes a violation of *ijjih*, the moral system governing an individual's behavior (cf. Guéron 2005: chap. 3; Lovick 2016, Lovick & Tuttle 2019 for more discussion of Upper Tanana *ijjih*; similar concepts are described for many Alaskan Dene groups). Making plans for the future, or expressing an expectation about what the future will be like (or that the future will be good), is to court bad luck, and is thus consistently avoided (Scollon & Scollon 1981: 20). Nelson (1973: 194–195) notes the unreliability of the weather in interior Alaska, and the difficulty even experienced hunters encounter when trying to predict the weather. The natural world is thought to be too large to be a safe discussion topic; Nelson (1983: 45) reports that Koyukon children are often reminded of the need for humility in the face of nature using the admonition “Don’t talk; your mouth is too small.”

As a consequence, the Upper Tanana Dene place a lot of cultural value on the concept of *ts’edòònih*, an uninflectable word of uncertain lexical category often translated as ‘you don’t know what’s gonna happen’ (author’s fieldnotes) or ‘you never know’ (Kari 1997). Implicit in the concept of *ts’edòònih* is the recognition that there are many things beyond an individual’s control, and the awareness that it is each person’s responsibility to be prepared for all of them at all times. Part of this preparedness is the need to look out for one another, as articulated by Mrs. Avis Sam (N) in a recent text about *ts’edòònih* (1).¹

¹All data is presented in the practical orthography. Tone is not usually indicated in the practical orthography but marked in the bulk of the data in this paper, with the exception of the published data from the Scottie Creek dialect (Tyone 1996), which is presented as in the original source. High tone, associated with standard negation and several lexical items, is marked for all data from the Beaver Creek, Northway, and Tetlin dialects. Low tone originating from Proto-Dene constriction (Krauss 2005) is marked for the Northway and Beaver Creek data but not for the Tetlin data, as low tone is not phonemic in that variety (Minoura 1994, Lovick 2020a).

- (1) *Nil-'èh na-ts'i-dek dè' ts'iikeey iin*
 RECP.PO-with PRMB-1PL.S:Ø.IPFV:Ø-PL.go:IPFV:CUST when children PL
ts'edòònih xà' hqqsú'
 never.know because well
nil-k'à-nal-tà'. (N)
 RECP.PO-care-QUAL:Ø.IPFV:2PL.S:L-take.care:IPFV
 'When we walk around together, children, take good care of each other
 because of *ts'edòònih*. [UTOLAF19Jan0501:019]

In addition to this general mindset of circumspection, Alaskan Dene traditionally perform numerous small, often ritualistic acts that serve to prevent undesirable events or to ensure favorable outcomes. This is illustrated in (2), which describes the proper placement of whitefish on a drying rack in the Upper Tanana area.²

- (2) a. *A-dógn da-ts'e-leeg tah chih*
 NTRL-up:AR up-1PL.S:Ø.IPFV:H-handle.PL.O:IPFV:CUST:NMZ when also
k'at'eey né' nts'q' k'a
 NEG backward:ALL ADVZR NEG
da-tsaa-dláál u-tthi' ts'qy
 up-1PL.S:INC:AA.IPFV:Ø-keep.PL.O:FUT:NEG 3PL.PSR-head side
a-nóó ts'q' shyíí' da-tsaa-taat
 NTRL-ahead:ALL ADVZR only up-1PL.S:INC:AA.IPFV:Ø-keep.PL.O:FUT
u-tthi'. (T)
 3PL.PSR-head
 'Also when we put [whitefish] up [on the drying rack], we may not
 keep it up there backward, we have to keep it there with the sides of
 the head facing forward, their heads.' [UTOLVDN11Jul2903:003]
- b. *Ay tah chih k'at'eey kel na-tat-dlqá*
 3SG when also NEG ? IT-3PL.S:INC:AA.IPFV:D-be.many:FUT:NEG
he-ndiik na-né' nts'q'
 3PL.S:Ø.IPFV:Ø-say:IPFV MED-backward:ALL ADVZR
da-hiiy-eh-leek tah.
 up-3PL>3PL-Ø.IPFV:Ø-handle.PL.O:IPFV:CUST when
 'There won't be as many, they say, when they put them up facing
 backward.' [UTOLVDN11Jul2903:004]

²Whitefish are caught during their annual migration to their spawning grounds, hence there is a 'forward' and a 'backward' relative to the direction of their migration.

There are countless acts such as these; Nelson et al. (1982: chs. 3, 4, 9, 14) list a large number of them for the Koyukon people, but are careful to note that there are many more. Lists of these acts, and of the consequences they are intended to avert, are a rich source for aversive linkings (see also §4).

Knowledge of these acts is part and parcel of being an Alaskan Dene; in the Upper Tanana area, this is one component of “knowing one’s *ijjih*” (author’s field-notes), i.e. having a solid grasp of cultural knowledge. A competent individual is expected to know (and ideally adhere to) their *ijjih*, and Upper Tanana speakers are very careful not to suggest that an individual’s knowledge of *ijjih* is deficient (cf. Lovick 2016: 273).

This last point is linked to another fundamental tenet of Northern Dene culture: non-interference with another’s autonomy (cf. Scollon & Scollon 1981 for Alaskan Dene, Rushforth & Chisholm 1991 for Bearlake Dene, or Basso 1979, 1990 for Western Apache). A direct consequence of this attitude is a general reluctance to utter questions and requests (Scollon & Scollon 1981). These authors note that both types of speech act are routinely avoided, while Rushforth (1985) and Rushforth & Chisholm (1991) observe a marked preference for indirect requesting strategies.³ Lovick (2016) finds that, while direct affirmative requests are common in Upper Tanana, their form depends on the relationship between the interlocutors as well as on the imposition resulting from complying with the request. Negative requests are strongly avoided in Upper Tanana (cf. Lovick 2016, Lovick & Tuttle 2019), not merely because of the principle of non-interference, but also because they could be interpreted as suggesting that the addressee’s knowledge of *ijjih* is deficient.

Thus, traditional Upper Tanana speakers are very circumspect both in words and actions. Verbally, they avoid interfering in another’s autonomy, making predictions about the future, or talking about things for which their “mouth is too small”. Practically, they value careful, often symbolic, interactions with animate and inanimate entities, as well as preparedness for all matters outside their control.

1.2 Upper Tanana language

Upper Tanana is a Northern Dene language spoken by 30–50 mostly elderly speakers in eastern interior Alaska and the Yukon Territory. Minoura (1994) identifies five dialects; this paper contains data from my own fieldwork on the North-

³This is also the reason for my terminological choice to talk about requests rather than commands.

way (N), Tetlin (T), and Beaver Creek (B) dialects as well as from a story collection (Tyone 1996) in the Scottie Creek (S) dialect.

Morphologically, Upper Tanana can be classified as polysynthetic, incorporating, and fusional. It is characterized by particularly rich verbal morphology which can be represented by the template indicating morpheme order in Table 1.

Table 1: The Upper Tanana verb, represented as a template

12	11	10	9	8	7	#	6	5	4	3	2	1	0	-1
Postpositional object						-								
Postposition														
Adverbial-derivational														
Iterative														
Incorporate														
Distributive														
- Disjunct boundary														
Pronominal														
Qualifier														
Conjugation														
Mode														
Subject														
Voice/valence														
Stem														
Suffix														

The basic lexical unit in the verbal domain is the *verb theme* which consists minimally of a verb stem and a voice/valence marker. Many verb themes contain additional lexical prefixes and form the basis for further derivations. There are no nonfinite verb forms; each verb is obligatorily inflected for subject (positions 2 or 6 in the template), conjugation (position 4) and mode (position 3). Transitive verb themes are inflected for direct object (position 6). Morphemes in positions 6–1 often fuse into a single syllable, which I gloss as a portmanteau here and in other work, with zero expression indicated in the gloss (see Lovick 2020a: 6–10 for background on Upper Tanana glossing specifically and Hargus et al. 2020 for more information on glossing conventions in Dene languages). Other lexical classes have much more limited morphology; nouns can be inflected for possessor and (free) postpositions for postpositional object.

Upper Tanana distinguishes four *modes*: imperfective, perfective, optative, and future.⁴ The first two encode viewpoint aspect, while the latter two have modal functions. The optative expresses primarily deontic modality such as desire or obligation, while the future has mostly epistemic functions (Lovick 2017). The formation of all modes involves prefixes (conjugation and mode in Table 1) as well as stem changes originating in historic suffixation (Leer 1979); the future additionally requires the presence of the inceptive prefix (one of the qualifiers in

⁴The label *modes* is somewhat misleading, but for lack of a better term, I continue to use it here.

Table 1). Upper Tanana also has productive negative inflection as illustrated in (3). Negative inflection is used only in standard negation and involves changes in the conjugation/mode domain as well as a negative suffix which is absorbed into the stem syllable with sometimes idiosyncratic effects; in (3b), it voices the stem-final consonant. Standard negation also involves tonal changes; the unmarked pre-stem syllable in (3a) becomes low in the negative form, while all stems (unmarked and low-marked alike) become high. Standard negation additionally requires the presence of the negator *k'à(t'ee)* under most circumstances.

- (3) a. *shyi' ij-'ààl* (N)
 meat 3SG.S:AA.PFV:Ø-eat:PFV
 's/he ate the meat' [UTCBAF13Nov0802:008]
- b. *k'àt'ee shyi' i-'áál* (N)
 NEG meat 3SG.S:NEG.PFV:Ø-eat:PFV:NEG
 's/he didn't eat the meat' [UTCBAF13Nov0802:009]

Upper Tanana is generally verb-final, although some syntactic material may follow the verb. Arguments of verbs and postpositions as well as nominal possessors may be expressed by free noun phrases or marked on the verb, postposition, or noun.

Important for the discussion in this paper is the structure of adverbial clauses, which are characterized by the presence of a clause-final subordinator. Many subordinators are formally identical to postpositions and require nominalization of the verb (marked formally by a historical vocalic suffix which is absorbed into the verb stem; common effects of this suffix include voicing of stem-final consonants, deletion of stem-final *h*, and lengthening of the stem vowel);⁵ many also require the verb in either clause to be in a particular mode. The order of adverbial clause and main clause is generally free but often follows iconic principles. Two types of adverbial clauses are illustrated in (4).

- (4) a. *Ay èh dhij-t'eh* *dè' shit*
 and DH.PFV:2SG.S:Ø-get.burned:PFV if scar
taa-'aal. (N)
 3SG.S:INC:AA.IPFV:Ø-classify.CO:FUT
 'And if you get burned, there will be a scar.'
 [UTOLVDN14Apr2601:051]

⁵In his description of Dëne Suliné, Cook (2004: 375–381) argues in favor of treating such clauses as nominal objects of postpositions.

- b. ... *ishyiit nii-ts'in-deel*
 there TERM:IT-1PL.S:N.PFV:D-PL.go:PFV
na-nts'-uu-'aal *xah* ... (N)
 CONT-1PL>INDF-OPT:Ø-eat:OPT:NMZ PURP
 '... we went back there in order to eat ...' [UTOLVDN14Apr2602:115]

Example (4a) illustrates a conditional linking formed using the subordinator *dè* 'if, when.FUT', which is formally identical to the postposition *po+dè* 'at a time *po* in the future'. This subordinator does not generally cause nominalization. The verb in the condition may be in any mode, while the verb in the consequent is almost always in the future. The condition usually, but not necessarily, precedes the consequent.

(4b) illustrates a purposive clause formed using the subordinator *xah* ‘in order to, PURP’, related to the postposition *po+xah* ‘for po, because of po’.⁶ This subordinator usually triggers nominalization of the subordinate verb. Purpose clauses are always in the optative; there are no mode restrictions on the verb in the main clause. The main clause usually precedes the purpose clause.

Also important for this paper is the formation of (affirmative) requests, originally described in Lovick (2016). The two most common types described there are requests in the imperfective and optative modes (5).

- (5) a. “*Jah shyi’ ay iin tl’a-’ah-tee*,”
 this meat 3 PL to-Ø.IPFV:2PL.S:Ø-handle:PL.O:IPFV:IMP
nee-’eh-niik.
 1PL.O-3SG.S:Ø.IPFV:H-say:IPFV:CUST
 “Give (PL) them the meat here,” he would say to us.
 [UTCBAF13Nov1203:039]
- b. *Mb-aa n-che’ ski-dqq-teey* ...
 3SG.P-for 2SG.PSR-tail across-QUAL:OPT:2SG.S:Ø-handle.LRO:OPT
 ‘Put your (SG) tail across for him ...’ [UTOLVDN14Nov2301:359]

Generally, requests in the imperfective are used when the speaker is comfortable making a request, either because of the relationship between the interlocutors (e.g. a father addressing his children as in (5a), or an interaction between close friends or siblings) or because of the trivial nature of the action to be performed (Lovick 2016: 280–283). Requests in the optative are used, by contrast,

⁶This subordinator is also used in causal clauses with the meaning 'because', which have a slightly different structure from the purpose clauses described here.

in situations where the request is an imposition, either because of the nature of the action to be performed or because of a less easy relationship between the speaker and the addressee. In (5b), the speaker is addressing a Fox—a stranger to her. Optative requests are used in situations where the speaker does not feel entitled to making a request at all (Lovick 2016: 283–285).

1.3 Data

The bulk of the data for this study comes from a corpus comprising over 8,000 utterances of mostly narrative text recorded and processed by the author between 2006–2019. About 15 speakers are represented there, but the majority of text comes from two speakers of the Tetlin dialect and four speakers of the Northway dialect. Another 2,000 or so utterances come from the story collection by Mary Tyone (1996) in the Scottie Creek dialect. I mined this corpus for instances of avertive clauses using a string search for the avertive subordinator *ch'à'* and the urgent request marker *dè'*. I also searched for common translations of both construction, e.g. “so that ... not”, “to prevent that”, or “make sure”. Selected examples were discussed with speakers during the transcription and translation process; the notes I took during those discussions also fed into this paper.

The narrative corpus is supplemented by targeted elicitation. Elicitation of avertive clauses followed the methodology outlined in Vuillermet (2018). Using the contact language (English), I developed a scenario, e.g., walking about in the bush. I then asked for a translation of a target sentence into Upper Tanana, e.g., ‘I am going to boil the water so I don’t get sick from it’ and discussed the result with the speaker(s): is this the only way of saying it? What other ways of expressing this are there? Why did you phrase it this way? I found that the best results were obtained when speakers could work in pairs, since they could discuss the translation with each other, but this was not always feasible.

Direct elicitation of apprehensional requests is more challenging (see Lovick 2016, Lovick & Tuttle 2019 for discussion of the challenges of request elicitation), so instead, I selected examples from the corpus and discussed those with speakers, paying attention to how changing the form of the request would impact its meaning and use.

All data collected by the author or her team is cited by its corpus identifier.

2 Avertive linkings

Avertive linkings are a type of adverbial linking. The structural properties of avertive linkings and some structural restrictions are described in §2.1. Their

semantics is discussed in §2.2; alternative constructions with similar semantics are described in §2.3. In §2.4 I show that averative linkings with similar structural properties are attested in several other Dene languages. The origin of the averative subordinator used in all of these languages is discussed in §2.5. This section closes with a discussion of the relative frequency of averative linkings in different speech acts.

2.1 Structural properties

Averative linkings always involve the subordinator *ch'a'* 'AVERT, lest' in clause-final position. The verb in the averative clause is usually in the future (6a)–(6c) or in the inceptive perfective mode, which often has the meaning of 'immediate future' ((6d), cf. Lovick 2017). The averative clause (bolded throughout this paper) usually follows the main clause (6a)–(6c), but the opposite order is also attested (6d).

- (6) a. *Huu-la'* *tah* *chih tl'uul net-chüh*
 3PL.PSR-hand among also rope 3SG.S:QUAL:DH.PFV:D-be.tied:PFV
huu-laa-güü *taa-leel* ***ch'a'***. (S)
 3PL.PSR-finger-finger-forked 3SG.S:INC:AA.IPFV:Ø-be:FUT:NMZ AVERT
 'Rope was tied between their fingers **to prevent them from [having] spaces between their fingers.**' (Tyone 1996: 19)
- b. *Di-nijj'* *t'eeey hiiy-ee-k'ia* *dégn' nts'q'*
 REFL.PSR-face ADVZR 3PL>3PL-DH.PFV:Ø-exercise:PFV up:ALL ADVZR
na-h-nal-xon ***ch'a'*** ... (T)
 down-3PL.S-INC:QUAL:AA.IPFV:L-sag:FUT:NMZ AVERT
 'They train their faces upward (i.e. they wash their faces with upward motions) **to prevent them from sagging down ...**'
 [UTOLVDN11Jul2901:033]
- c. *Ay xah* ***doo iin nijj-deel*** *iin*
 3SG because who PL 3PL.S:N.PFV:Ø-PL.go:PFV:NMZ PL
i-tjl-nüü ***ch'a'*** *ay xah* *ch'a'*
 PP-INC:AA.IPFV:2SG.S:L-forget:FUT:NMZ AVERT 3SG because FOC
hu'eh *dhijdah.* (N)
 3PL.PO-with DH.PFV:2SG.S:Ø-SG.sit:IPFV
 'That's why, **so you don't forget those who came**, that is why you sit with them.'
 [UTOLVDN14May0508:038]

- d. *Ay tl'ààn tuu tèt-shyoo ch'à'*
 and.then water 3SG.S:INC:DH.PFV:D-get.splashed:PFV:NMZ AVERT
hà-ni-t'ah, dits'än. (N)
 up/out-3SG.S:N.IPFV:Ø-SG.fly:IPFV duck
 'And to avoid getting splashed, the duck flies up.'
 [UTOLVDN07Aug2205:048]

The main clause in an aversive linking may have any person subject: third person in (6a), (6b), (6d), second person in (6c), and first person in (7).

- (7) *Nts'q̄q' tat-xòl ch'à' nts'q̄q' laan*
 how 3PL.S:INC:AA.IPFV:D-break:FUT:NMZ AVERT how truly
ts'uh-ìì? (N)
 1PL.S:OPT:H-act:OPT
 'What should we do so [the eggs] won't break?'
 [UTOLVDN07Aug2205:054]

Similarly, there are no person restrictions on the aversive clause's subject. While third person seems the most common ((6a)–(6c), (7)), second person (6d) and first person (8) are attested. There also is no co-reference requirement between the two clauses' subjects ((6)–(8)).

- (8) *"Sh-taay, tl'uul sh-tl'ädñ hi-'ih-shüh*
 1SG.PSR-paternal.uncle rope 1SG.PSR-waist PP-Ø.IPFV:2SG.S:H-tie:IPFV
sta-tih-haal ch'a'," ... (S)
 away-INC:AA.IPFV:1SG.S:Ø-SG.go:FUT:NMZ AVERT
 "My uncle, tie a rope around my waist lest I run away," ...'
 (Tyone 1996: 26)

While the aversive clause is always in the future or the inceptive perfective, there appear to be no mode restrictions on the main clause.

2.1.1 Structural restrictions

The only structural restriction on aversive linkings is that the main clause has to be affirmative. Aversive linkings with negated main clauses are not attested in the corpus, nor could they be elicited.⁷ Speakers consistently employ different constructions, e.g. (9a), where the undesirable consequence of tooth decay is expressed by a causal clause, or (9b), where Raven's feared theft of the sun is expressed by simple juxtaposition.

⁷This is true for standard negation, negative requests, and negation of existence.

- (9) a. ... *k'à hii-nel-déél*, *hu-ts'änh*
 NEG 3PL.S>3PL.O-QUAL:Ø.IPFV:L-eat:PL.O:IPFV:NEG 3PL.PO-from
hu-xù' tah-jiit xah. (B)
 3PL.PSR-teeth 3PL.INC:AA.IPFV:H-rot:FUT because
 '... they do not eat [cranberries], because their teeth will rot from
 them.' [UTOLVDN10Jul2602:063]
- b. *Sq' ay chih èh dul-xoo, áñ*
 PROH 3SG too with 3SG.S:OPT:L-play:OPT outside:ALL
y-èh tthi-taa-haal! (N)
 3SG.S>3SG.PO-with out-INC:AA.IPFV:Ø-SG.go:FUT
 'Don't let him play with [the sun], he will go outside with it!'
 [UTOLAF18Jun1001:009]

The reason for this is unclear. The small overall number of avertive linkings in the corpus (see §2.6) raises the possibility that this is an accidental gap, but the fact that elicitation of avertive linkings with negative or prohibitive main clauses consistently yielded constructions similar to those in (9) suggests that this is a true structural restriction.

2.2 Semantic properties

Semantically, the avertive clause expresses an undesirable event that can be prevented by taking the action expressed in the main clause. Pubescent girls traditionally were not supposed to spread their fingers; to avoid this, their fingers were tied together (6a).⁸ (6b) describes a measure to prevent skin aging. (6c) is about courtesy to potlatch visitors; the person putting on a potlatch has the responsibility of spending a little time with each visitor so they will remember who came (and give gifts appropriately). (6d) describes duck behavior that is exploited for egg gathering.

Undesirability is a semantic component of this construction, not a pragmatic implicature. Avertive clauses cannot be used in situations where the possible consequence is not undesirable. In most cases, the event in the avertive clause is intrinsically undesirable, but this is not required. (10) comes from elicitation. The scenario given to the speakers was that several children are playing hide-and-seek. Two of them are sharing a hiding spot. When the seeker comes close,

⁸One anonymous reviewer suggests that this may be to avoid the appearance of witchcraft, which in some Dene groups involves hand gestures. To my knowledge, nothing of the sort is reported for the Upper Tanana (or related Alaskan Dene) area, but this may be due to a general reluctance to discuss such topics.

the girl is about to make a noise: either a scream (intrinsically undesirable; (10a)) or a giggle (situationally undesirable; (10b)). The speakers originally suggested the negated purposive clause in (10c) to express the scenario involving laughter, but decided after some discussion that the avertive clause in (10b) was preferable. (The problematic status of negated purposive clauses in Upper Tanana is discussed in §2.3.)⁹

- (10) a. *D-ijlā' u-thaat*
 REFL.PSR-hand 3SG.PSR-mouth
da-dìh-'qq
 closed-3SG.S:QUAL:AA.PFV:H-handle.CO:PFV
taa-säl ch'à' . (N)
 3SG.S:INC:AA.IPFV:Ø-scream:FUT:NMZ AVERT
 'He put his hand over her mouth so she wouldn't scream.'
 [UTOLAF18Jun0805:002]
- b. [*D-ijlā' u-thaat*
 REFL.PSR-hand 3SG.PSR-mouth
da-dìh-'qq]
 closed-3SG.S:QUAL:AA.PFV:H-handle.CO:PFV
taa-dlòò ch'à' . (N)
 3SG.S:INC:AA.IPFV:Ø-laugh:FUT:NMZ AVERT
 '[He put his hand over her mouth] so she wouldn't laugh.'
 [UTOLAF18Jun0805:004]
- c. ? *D-ijlā' u-thaat*
 REFL.PSR-hand 3SG.PSR-mouth
da-dìh-'qq k'à
 closed-3SG.S:QUAL:AA.PFV:H-handle.CO:PFV NEG
uu-dlóó xah. (N)
 3SG.S:OPT:Ø-laugh:OPT:NEG PURP
 'He put his hand over her mouth so she wouldn't laugh.'
 [UTOLAF18Jun0805:001]

The undesirability is evaluated from the perspective of the subject of the main clause. The girl who utters (11a) wants to escape, but the addressee, her evil “uncle”, wants her to stay. In (11b), people are trying to prevent a man whose only son has just drowned in a boat accident from taking his own life by walking out into the lake.

⁹In (10b), the speaker did not repeat the main clause, hence it is included here in brackets.

- (11) a. *“Sh-taay, tl’uul sh-tl’ädn hi-’ih-shüh*
 1SG.PSR-paternal.uncle rope 1SG.PSR-waist PP-Ø.IPFV:2SG.S:H-tie:IPFV
sta-tih-haal ch’a’,” ... (S)
 away-INC:AA.IPFV:1SG.S:Ø-SG.go:FUT:NMZ AVERT
 “My uncle, tie a rope around my waist **lest I run away**,” ...’
 (Tyone 1996: 26)
- b. *Ay du’ nahugn diniign thüh tl’uul’ heh-tsij*
 and CT there moose skin rope:POSS 3PL.S:DH.PFV:H-make.SG.O:PFV
ay hii-’i-nih-tl’qo el nóó
 and 3PL>3SG-PP-N.PFV:H-tie:PFV and ahead:ALL
ch’aa-’i-mbeek
 out:PRMB-3SG.S:Ø.IPFV:Ø-SWIM:IPFV:CUST
ti-taa-haal ch’a’. (T)
 underwater-3SG.S:INC:AA.IPFV:Ø-SG.go:FUT:NMZ AVERT
 ‘And they made a moose skin rope and tied it around him [when] he
 walked out into the water, **so he would not go under [and drown**
himself].’
 [UTOLAF10Jul0801:023]

2.2.1 Semantic restrictions on avertive clauses

The most important semantic restriction on avertive clauses in Upper Tanana is that the event expressed in the avertive clause actually can be prevented by the action in the main clause; i.e. the subject of the main clause has control over the event in the avertive clause.¹⁰ One can prevent a person from running away or drowning themselves by physically restraining them (11), and screaming or giggling can be prevented, or at least subdued, by placing a hand over a person’s mouth (10), but, as the elicited example in (12) shows, one cannot prevent a child from grabbing a knife by merely watching him or her, and thus an avertive linking cannot be used.

¹⁰This contrasts sharply with the situation described by Wiemer (2026 [this volume]) for several Slavic languages, where uncontrollability, i.e. the fact that “neither a discourse participant (in particular the addressee) nor a third party can influence the course of events”, is an integral component of what Wiemer terms “apprehensional strategies”. This is illustrated abundantly by the examples brought by Wiemer, where possible events to be avoided or prevented, include weather events such as rain or droughts, catching cold or other diseases, or war breaking out.

- (12) *Ts'iiniin k'à-nìh-tà',* **seeyh**
 child care-QUAL:Ø.PFV:2SG.S:H-take.care:IPFV knife
uu-taa-nik! (N)
 3SG:CON-INC:AA.IPFV:Ø-grab:FUT
 'Take care of/watch the baby, he might grab the knife!'
[UTOLAF18Jun0803:003]

The scenario in the elicited example (13) involves the speaker getting into an argument with an obnoxious stranger at the grocery store. The cue used was 'Shut up so I don't beat you up!'. A causal linking is used instead of an avertive one.

- (13) *Da-dhìj-náy,*
 LEX-DH.IPFV:2SG.S:Ø-say:IPFV:NEG
n-nak-gòt **xah! (N)**
 2SG.O-INC:QUAL:AA.IPFV:1SG.S:H-punch:FUT because
 'Shut up, because I might punch you!' [UTOLAF18Jun0803:020]

The speakers rejected my suggestion of *nnakgòt ch'à'* 'lest I punch you' with the rationale that your shutting up may not be sufficient to keep me from punching you: a rude gesture or facial expression might, after all, provoke me just as much as continued talking would. Another reason for the avoidance of an avertive linking could be that the verb in the main clause is formally negative.¹¹ I am however uncertain whether speakers recognize this as a negative form due to the degree of fossilization and the lack of negative particles.

In 'in-case' scenarios like the elicited example in (14), avertive clauses can never be used; see §4 for more discussion.

- (14) *Eh Bill: Tay' t'ey tah-chaan* *ay xah*
 and Bill again ADVZR 3SG.S:INC:AA.IPFV:H-rain:FUT:NMZ 3SG because
ch'ale u-shyii chq taathüh di-dhih-dlay
 FOC 3SG.PO-in umbrella QUAL-DH.PFV:1SG.S:Ø-keep.PL.O:IPFV:NMZ
tthiishyoh eh tl'aan dii na-ti-dhag-niign
 hat and and what PRMB-INC-DH.PFV:1SG.S:L-wear:IPFV:CUST:NMZ

¹¹*Dadhìjny* 'shut up' is one of a handful of fossilized morphologically formed prohibitives containing the negative prefix *dh-* otherwise lost in Upper Tanana (Kari 1993, van Gelderen 2008); Lovick (2020a: 472). The structure of *dadhìjny* 'shut up' is discussed in some more detail in Lovick (2020b).

tat'eey u-shyii dhih-dlah. (T)

also 3SG.PO-in DH.PFV:1SG.S:Ø-keep.PL.O:IPFV

‘And Bill: It might rain again, that’s why I keep the umbrella in [the backpack] and the hat and my clothes I also keep in it.’

[UTCBAF13Nov1510:035]

2.3 Alternative constructions

A number of strategies can be used when an avertive linking is not possible due to semantic or structural restrictions. As shown in the preceding sections, both juxtaposition (9a) and causal clauses (9b), (13) and (14) occur with some frequency, but there are additional options. In ‘in-case’ scenarios, temporal linkings with *ttheh* ‘before’ are a common strategy (15).

- (15) “*Nah-ógn tah-shyüüdn ttheh*

MED-out:AR INC:AA.IPFV:H-SNOW:FUT:NMZ before

na-tsut-dèèl,” he-nih. (N)

IT-1PL.S:INC:OPT:D-PL.go:OPT 3PL.S:Ø.IPFV:Ø-say:IPFV

“‘Let’s go back before it snows,” they said.’ [UTCBAF15May0403:039]

In the speech of at least one speaker, *ttheh* has been extended to have avertive meaning as well (16).

- (16) *Ni-h-teedak ttheh “Nah-’óg*

up-3PL.S-INC:DH.PFV:Ø-PL.go:PFV before MED-out:ALL

na-h-tet-dag iin,” nih

PRMB-3PL.S-INC:Ø.IPFV:D-PL.go:IPFV:CUST:NMZ PL say

hu-’i-chi-jel-nih. (T)

3PL.PO-PP-LIE-INDF:3SG.S:QUAL:Ø.IPFV:L-lie:IPFV

‘To prevent them getting up, “There’s people walking about outside,” she said, she lied to them.’ [UTOLVDN13May2909:067]

(16) is taken from a narrative where a young woman has been abducted by warriors. Her brothers have come to rescue her and are killing her captors outside the tent where she is being held. The men inside the tent hear the noises of the killing, but to prevent them from discovering the slaughter outside, she lies to them, pretending that the noises outside are normal and harmless. Temporal linkings with an avertive interpretation also occur in elicitation (17):

- (17) *U-ch'a' ch'i-nag-'ij*
 3SG.PO-from INDF-N.PFV:1SG.S:L-hide.self:PFV
sh-oo-dah-'aal *ttheh.* (T)
 3SG.S>1SG.O-CON-INC:QUAL:AA.IPFV:H-find:CO:FUT:NMZ before
 'I'm hiding from him to prevent him from finding me.'
 [UTOLAF18Jun0201:016]

It seems however that the undesirability of the event in the subordinate clause is implicated rather than part of the semantic meaning of the construction. The snow in (15), for example, is not necessarily undesirable, although it is preferable to travel in dry conditions; nor is being found in a game of hide-and-seek in (17) generally problematic.

In the discussion of the semantics of avertive linkings, the potential existence of a negative purposive linking such as (10c) was noted. Such linkings are attested primarily in elicited examples such as that in (18); to facilitate structural comparison, an affirmative purposive clause is provided in (19).

- (18) ? *Olga da-dégn' hq̣q-heeyh* *k'at'eey*
 Olga PROX-up:ALL 3SG.S:QUAL:QUAL:Ø.IPFV:Ø-talk:IPFV:NMZ NEG
uh-ts'ígn *xah.* (N)
 3SG.S:OPT:H-be.sick:OPT:NEG PURP
 'Olga prays so she won't get sick.' [UTOLAF14Nov2203:025]
- (19) *Olga da-dégn' hq̣q-heeyh*
 Olga PROX-up:ALL 3SG.S:QUAL:QUAL:Ø.IPFV:Ø-talk:IPFV:NMZ
na-'ut-shye' *xah.* (N)
 IT-3SG.S:OPT:D-heal:PASS:OPT PURP
 'Olga prays so she'll get healed.' [UTOLAF14Nov2203:024]

Comparison of (18) and (19) suggests that standard negation of the verb in a purposive clause results transparently in a negated purposive clause. I suspect however that negated purposive clauses such as (10c) or (18) are due to influence from English. (18) was elicited immediately after (19), using the cue 'so she won't get sick'. Both the temporal proximity of the two examples (only one minute elapses between them on the recording) and the English cue may have primed the speaker towards producing an English calque. Looking through other elicited instances of negated purposive linkings, all of them occur following cues containing 'so (that) ... not'. Even more intriguing is the only clear textual example of this construction, given in (20).

- (20) *Ch'its'ə̀ə́ tsaa-nìl* *xah hòə́*
 wrong 1PL.S:INC:AA.IPFV:Ø-happen:FUT:NEG PURP thus
nił-ts'et-niik. (N)
 RECP.PO-1PL.S:Ø.IPFV:D-say:IPFV:CUST
 'So we won't do it wrong, we discuss it with each other.'
[UTOLVDN14May0508:114]

This utterance occurred about halfway through a 30 minute recording of four elders. For the first ten minutes, one elder talks about how to put on a traditional potlatch, and which pitfalls to avoid. When she is done, a second elder picks up the thread of proper potlatching. (20) is an utterance produced by the second elder. The subordinate clause is clearly negative despite the absence of the negative particle *k'ə́(t'ee)*, as evidenced by the tonal pattern. During a transcription and translation session in July 2019 with this same (second) elder, she confirmed that the verb form was formally negative (exaggerating the high tone) and suggested adding the negative particle.¹² I also asked her to evaluate the avertive clause *ch'its'ə̀ə́ ts'aanìl ch'ə́* 'lest we do it wrong' (without the tonal pattern associated with standard negation) instead of the negated purposive clause in (20). The speaker responded that the avertive clause would be vastly preferable to both the original version and the version including *k'ə́t'ee*, but that it sounded like a rare construction to her.

It is intriguing to compare (20) with (21), an utterance from earlier in the recording, produced by the first elder.¹³ This structure clearly contains a causal clause with the subordinator *xah* 'because', which always triggers nominalization of the subordinate verb. Crucially, the form *hihtaanìl* 'they might do/happen' is *not* formally negative as evidenced by the low stem tone: *xah* is produced at slightly higher pitch than the stem *nił*, which bears a lexical low tone.

- (21) *Hòə́ hudahnih*, *ayaa nts'ə́ t'ee*
 thus 3PL.PO-QUAL:2PL.S:Ø-say:IPFV bad ADVZR
hihtaanìl *xah*. (N)
 3PL.S:INC:AA.IPFV:Ø-happen:FUT:NMZ because
 'Tell (PL) them, because they might do it badly.'
[UTOLVDN14May0508:053]

After perusing the corpus carefully multiple times, I tentatively conclude that utterances such as (10c), (18), or (20) are English calques.

¹²The negative particle is almost always present, but there are occasional instances without it, as discussed in Lovick (2023).

¹³Both utterances are uttered in similar contexts: the need to consult with one's close relatives to ensure that gifts at the potlatch are given appropriately. Proper gift-giving at potlatch is a very involved process; see Simeone (1995).

2.4 Beyond Upper Tanana

Avertive linkings seem to be attested all across Northern Dene (22)–(25),¹⁴ with subordinators that are clearly cognate to Upper Tanana *ch'à*. The constructions in the two Alaskan languages Dena'ina (22) and Ahtna (23) are identical to that in Upper Tanana.

- (22) *Q'uch'a yadi ninya qyeghusltish dghu qyet*
 how whatever animal 3PL>3SG:skin:IPFV:CUST when 3PL>3SG:with
dnish tutnitutq'ashi k'u. (Dena'ina)
 3PL.S:know:IPFV:CUST 3PL.S:cut.skin:FUT:NMZ AVERT
 'They knew how to skin any animal **so as not to damage the skin.**'
 (Kalifornsky 1991: 260–261)

- (23) *Naltsiin 'iin du' xuts'enekaey stanxuhnel'iin xuhnal'iil*
 Naltsiin PL CT 3PL.PSR:children 3PL>3PL:hide.away:PFV 3PL>3PL:see:FUT
c'a', ... (Ahtna)
 AVERT
 'The Naltsiin had hidden their children **so [the Tailed People] wouldn't see them, ...**'
 (Kari 1986: 55)

In the two Canadian languages, the construction looks a little different. This is partially due to differences between the language groups; while future and negative polarity are inflectional categories in the Alaskan languages, they are expressed by postverbal particles or clitics in the Canadian ones. This likely explains the imperfective form in the avertive clause in the Dëne Sųliné example (24). The Slave example in (25) uses an optative form in the avertive clause, but most surprising is the fact that this form contains the negative enclitic =*hîle* (this enclitic is partly absorbed into the stem). The same is true for all other avertive linkings cited by Rice (1989), suggesting that the construction in Slave has undergone some changes, possibly under the influence of English contact.

- (24) *Hustón=ë yëkéth ch'á.* (Dëne Sųliné)
 1SG>3SG:hold:IPFV=FUT 3SG:fall.over:IPFV AVERT
 'I'll hold [the swingset] **so it doesn't fall over.**'
 [deslas-ANR-2016-07-10-C]

¹⁴Due to my insufficient familiarity with all of these languages, I only provide word-level glosses containing participant and mode/aspect information in this section.

- (25) *Daniel yegúh?ále* *ch'á* *goghádehk'a.* (Slave)
 Daniel 3SG>3SG:find.CO:OPT:NEG AVERT 1SG>3SG:throw.CO:PFV
 'I threw it so Daniel wouldn't find it.' (Rice 1989: 1262)

2.5 Origin and other uses of *ch'á*

The origin of the averative subordinator is likely the Proto-Dene postposition *PO*+ **k'ʷaŋ* 'away, apart from *PO*' (Leer 1996).¹⁵ In many daughter languages, cognates occur as a free or bound postposition with meanings such as 'separating *PO*, emanating from *PO*', or adverbial-derivational verb prefixes with the meaning 'out and away'. In the Alaskan languages (apparently not beyond), the meanings 'warding off *PO*, protecting against/from *PO*, keeping *PO* away' are also common.

In Upper Tanana, cognates of the Proto-Dene morpheme include the bound adverbial-derivational morpheme *ch'a-* 'out and away' which is restricted to motion verbs (26). This morpheme has purely spatial meaning without connotations of avoidance or fear.

- (26) a. *Ch'a-y-dih-tij* ... (T)
 out-3SG>3SG-QUAL-AA.PFV:H-handle.AO:PFV
 'She took him out [from between two spruce trees] ...'
 [UTOLAF09Jun2202:015]
 b. *Nóó* *ch'a-ts'i-nij-kij* *eh* ... (T)
 ahead:ALL out-1PL.S-N.PFV:Ø-go.by.boat:PFV and
 'We start out by boat and ...'
 [UTOLAF09Jun2902:011]

The free postposition *PO*+*ch'á* 'away from *PO*', by contrast, does have strong connotations of avoidance (27a, 27b), hiding (27c), or escape (27d). This last example was a prompt by me that was flagged as problematic by the speakers, who suggested (27e) instead. A sentence like (27d) would be appropriate if the postpositional object were some sort of evil creature, but not if it is a respected elder like Sherry—in that situation, the (purely spatial) ablative postposition like *PO*+*ts'ānh* 'from *PO*' in (27e) has to be used.

- (27) a. *Nts'q' na-tthi-ts'el-dak* *shyij' t'eeey, nih,*
 and CONT-out-1PL.S:Ø.IPFV:L-PL.go:IPFV:CUST only ADVZR say:IPFV
huk'an ch'a'. (T)
 burn-out from
 'And we were just running, she said, **from that burn-out.**'
 [UTOLAF09Jun2402:028]

¹⁵ A similar origin is observed by François (2026 [this volume]) for a comparable subordinator in several Torres-Banks languages.

- b. **Hu-ch'à'** *i-tal-ch'ee* ... (N)
 3PL.PO-from ?-3SG.S:INC:AA.IPFV:L-be.aloof:FUT
 [Money, success] will stay **away from them** ...'
 [UTOLAF12Jul1203:067]
- c. *S-seeyy'* *sta-tñih-'ijl*
 1SG.PSR-knife:POSS away-FUT:QUAL:AA.IPFV:2SG.S:H-hide:FUT:NMZ
sh-ch'a' ... (T)
 1SG.PO-from
 'You (SG) must have hidden my knife **away from me** ...'
 [UTOLVDN13May2804:077]
- d. ? **Sherry shyah ch'à'** *ih-haal*. (N)
 Sherry house from AA.IPFV:1SG.S:Ø-SG.go:IPFV:PROG
 (Intended: 'I'm coming **from Sherry's house**')
 Comment: 'Sounds like you're getting away from her.'
 [Prompt by OL for UTOLAF18Jun0101:087]
- e. **Sherry shyah ts'ānh** *ih-haal*. (N)
 Sherry house from AA.IPFV:1SG.S:Ø-SG.go:IPFV:PROG
 'I'm coming **from Sherry's house**.'
 [UTOLAF18Jun0101:087]

po+ch'à' also has non-spatial meanings as demonstrated in (28), but it retains its negative connotations.

- (28) a. *Chih nah-'ógn ni-'eel-ts'e-leek*
 also MED-out:AR TERM-trap-1PL.S:Ø.IPFV:L-handle.PL.O:IPFV:CUST
nts'q' t'eeý t'axoh ti-ts'at-ndak **u-ch'a'**. (T)
 ADVZR finally LEX-1PL.S:AA.PFV:D-be.tired:IPFV 3SG.PO-from
 'We would be setting traps too out there; finally we'd get tired **of it**.'
 [UTCBDN13Nov1501:096]
- b. **Ch'indziidn ch'à'** *dhih-säl*. (N)
 bee from DH.PFV:1SG.S:Ø-scream:PFV
 'I screamed **for fear of the bees**.'
 [UTOLAF18Jun0805:037]

(28b) comes from elicitation; the scenario given to speakers was that I was stung twelve times by bees the last time I stole honey: now the bees are after me again and I scream with fear.

The textual example (29) shows that the postposition po+ch'à' can also be used with clearly avertive function. The speaker explains why silence is expected during condolence visits. (29a) paints a scenario where the visitor is not silent;

the free pronoun *ay* in (29b) refers to that scenario. (Basso (1990: 90–92) reports a similar injunction against unnecessary conversation in encounters with the recently bereaved in the Western Apache context.)

- (29) a. *N-èh stoo-tnèl-nay èh*
 2SG.PO-with away:AR.S-INC:QUAL:DH.PFV:L-CO.moves:PFV:NMZ with
dij-nijl nts'q', shyqà' t'eeey
 INC:QUAL:AA.IPFV:2SG.S:Ø-say:FUT and for.nothing ADVZR
ha-tha-djh-nay dè'
 out-mouth-QUAL:AA.PFV:2SG.S:H-move.CO.carelessly:PFV:NMZ if
ch'its'qà' tah dij-nijl. (N)
 wrong among INC:QUAL:Ø.IPFV:2SG.S:Ø-say:FUT
 'You (SG) will talk when [your mind] is not all the way there, and if
 you (SG) just blab for no reason, you (SG) will say something wrong.'¹⁶
 [UTOLVDN14May0508:013]
- b. *Ay ch'à' shyqà' dhij-dah. (N)*
 3SG AVERT for.nothing DH.PFV:2SG.S:Ø-SG.sit:IPFV
 'To avoid that [i.e., saying the wrong thing], sit (SG) for nothing
 [without talking]. [UTOLVDN14May0508:014]

Although the postposition *PO+ch'à'* may have connotations of fear, the subordinator does not. Unlike what Lichtenberk (1995: 296–297) describes for the Austronesian language To'aba'ita, *ch'à'* is not attested in the corpus as a subordinator when the verb of the main clause is a predicate of fearing; instead, the complementizer *t'eeey* is used (30):

- (30) *Tee-te' t'eeey neljit! (T)*
 3SG.S:INC:DH.PFV:Ø-SG.sleep:PFV COMP 3SG.S:QUAL:Ø.PFV:L-be.scared:IPFV
 'She was scared to fall asleep!' [UTCBAF13Nov0501:086]

Ch'à' could also not be elicited with this function as shown in (31); the cues were 'I'm afraid the dog might bite me', 'I'm afraid they might kill us', and 'I'm afraid he will find me'.

¹⁶This sentence contains two fascinating morphological idioms. *Neh stootnelnay eh* 'when your mind is not all the way there' can be glossed more literally as 'when a compact object has moved independently away, affecting you', while *hathadjhnay* 'you just blab' could be glossed as 'you move a compact object carelessly out using your mouth'.

- (31) a. *Lj̥i sh-taa-'aal*
 dog 1SG.O-3SG.S:INC:AA.IPFV:Ø-bite:FUT
m-i-nag-jit. (T)
 3SG.PO-PP-QUAL:Ø.PFV:1SG.S:L-be.afraid:IPFV
 ‘The dog might bite me, I’m afraid of it.’ [UTOLAF18Jun0201:001]
- b. *Han iin hu-'i-nagn-jit,*
 DEM PL 3PL.PO-PP-QUAL:Ø.PFV:1SG.S:L-be.scared:IPFV
nee-h-taa-xqq *k'eh hel-tsj̥i. (N)*
 1PL.O-3PL.S-INC:AA.IPFV:Ø-kill.PL.O:FUT like 3PL.S:DH.PFV:L-seem:IPFV
 ‘I’m afraid of them, they look like they might kill us.’
 [UTOLAF18Jun0101:008]
- c. *Idzii sh-oo-dah-'aal. (T)*
 scary 1SG.O-3SG.S:QUAL-INC:QUAL:AA.IPFV:H-find.CO:FUT
 ‘Scary, he will find me.’ [UTOLAF18Jun0201:015]

2.6 Avertive clauses and speech acts

Dixon (2009: 24) notes that typologically, the main clause in an avertive construction (“possible consequence linking” in his terminology) is “most often a positive imperative ... or a negative one”.¹⁷ In Upper Tanana, this is not the case. As mentioned above, avertive clauses cannot be used at all with negative requests. With affirmative requests, they are rare. Table 2 shows that almost all naturalistic instances of avertive linking occur in declarative speech acts.

Table 2: Speech act types in avertive linkings

declarative	question	request	hortative	total
14	2	1	1	18

The total number of naturalistic examples of avertive clauses is so small (18 instances in about 10,000 utterances) that the relative frequencies have to be taken with a grain of salt. Yet it does appear as though Dixon’s claim about the predominance of avertive linkings in requests cannot be maintained for Upper Tanana. Since avertive linkings in requests can however be elicited without difficulty, the rarity of this construction is likely to have pragmatic rather than grammatical reasons. I suggest here that this is due to the availability of an urgent request

¹⁷The basis for his claim is unknown to me.

construction that points to, but does not spell out, potential undesirable consequences of non-compliance. These urgent requests are described in §3.

3 Urgent requests

The structure of urgent requests is described in §3.1. This is followed by a discussion of the origin of this construction in §3.2, and of its semantics in §3.3.

3.1 Structure

Urgent requests are in the optative and always contain the particle *dè'* (32).

- (32) *jin dɔh-'à' dhè' (B)*
 this QUAL:OPT:2SG.S:VV-sing:OPT please?
 'Sing (sg) this [song], you (sg) should sing this [song], please sing (sg)
 this [song].' [UTOLAF10Jul0202:196]

In discussing (32) and others like it, Lovick (2016: 269) suggests that the translation 'please' might be appropriate for this particle and that it serves to mitigate the request. More recent discussions with speakers, however, suggest a different function for this particle: that of adding urgency to a request, resulting in the translation 'make sure you sing this [song]' for (32), as discussed in §3.3.

3.2 Origin

The origin of urgent requests with *dè'* is likely a conditional request, which are a special type of conditional linking. In declarative conditional linkings, the conditional clause is marked by *dè'* 'if, when.FUT'. (This polysemy is common in Dene languages, see also Anisman 2019.) The consequent clause is usually in the future.

- (33) *Ay and ay tl'ààn udzih dhèh-xji dhè'*
 and and and then caribou 3SG.S:QUAL:DH.PFV:H-kill.SG.O:PFV if
nah-'óó nìi-taa-leel. (N)
 MED-out:ABL TERM.IT-3SG.S:INC:AA.IPFV:Ø-handle.PL.O:PFV
 'And if he'd kill a caribou, he'd bring it from out there.'
 [UTOLVDN07Nov2901:020]

Conditional requests differ from conditional declaratives in two respects: the consequent is usually in the optative, and both clauses contain the particle *dè'* (34).

- (34) a. *K'at'eey k'at'eey hoqsú' m-i-hql-náy* *dè' t'eey,*
 NEG NEG good 3SG.P-PP-AR:Ø.PFV:L-taste:IPFV:NMZ if even
at-naah *dè', nih.* (N)
 OPT:2PL.S:D-drink:OPT UR say:IPFV
 ‘‘Even if it doesn’t taste good, make sure you (PL) drink it,’’ he said.’
 [UTOLAF18Jun0401:013]
- b. *Ch'i-dhih-'eel* *de', k'a' qq-keet* *de',*
 INDF.O-DH.PFV:2SG.S:H-trap:PFV if gun OPT:2SG.S:Ø-buy:OPT UR
huugn ta-'ql-shyeeek *de', ...* (T)
 etc. distribute-OPT:2SG.S:L-handle.PL.O:OPT:DIST UR
 ‘And if you (SG) trap something, make sure you (SG) buy guns with it,
 make sure you (SG) distribute it [at potlatch] ...’
 [UTCBAF13Nov0401:070]

The presence of *dè'* ‘if, when.FUT’ in both clauses in conditional requests suggests that the consequent clause sets up a further condition with an unspoken consequence: even if the broth doesn’t taste good, make sure you drink it; if you do not drink it, you will die of starvation.¹⁸ If you have good luck trapping, make sure to distribute your wealth through a potlatch; if you fail to do so, you will no longer be successful when trapping. Full conditional requests like those in (34) thus are instances of insubordination (Evans 2007), where the main clause is unspoken, and where the (second) conditional clause is modified by the first conditional clause. Urgent requests such as (32) lack the first conditional clause.

3.3 Semantics

Urgent requests with *dè'* imply the presence of undesirable consequences of non-compliance, such as snow out of season in the case of (32), starvation in (34a), or poor luck in trapping in (34b). More examples are given in (35).

- (35) a. *Tl'aan hu-na-chin-'ah-deet* *tl'aan*
 and 3PL.P-surround-group-OPT:2PL.S:Ø-PL.move:OPT and
hu-b-e-kon'-nah-shyiiit *de'*
 3PL.P-?-PP-fire-QUAL:OPT:2PL.S:H-strike.LRO:OPT UR
hu-'ah-xqq *de', nee-he-nih.* (T)
 3PL.O-OPT:2PL.S:H-kill.PL.O:OPT UR 1PL.P-3PL.S:Ø-IPFV:Ø-say:IPFV
 ‘Then gang (PL) up on them and make sure you (PL) set fire to them
 and kill them, they said to us.’ [UTCBDVN14Jul1801:127]

¹⁸The broth in question is prepared from moose droppings and consumed only under the most dire circumstances.

- b. *Nts'q̣q̣' n-dih-nih niign t'eeɣ*
 whatever 2SG.P-QUAL:1SG.S:Ø-say:IPFV COMP ADVZR
ḍoq̣-ḍi' *ḍe', u-dih-nih. (N)*
 QUAL:OPT:2SG.S:Ø-do:IPFV APPR 3SG.P-QUAL:1SG.S:Ø-say:IPFV
 'Make sure you (SG) do [exactly] whatever I tell you (SG), I said to
 him.' [UTOLVDN13May2004:067]

(35a) is taken from a text about World War II, where US army representatives instructed the people of Tetlin village on what to do if they were attacked by the Japanese. Non-compliance here would have resulted not only in the death of many villagers, but also in the Japanese establishing a foothold on the Alaskan mainland, something the US army desperately wanted to avoid. (35b) (discussed at length in Lovick 2016) is from a text where the speaker and her brothers are attacked by a bear, but only have a single shot between them. The speaker is trying to protect her brothers from the bear; when her older brother starts arguing, she shuts him up with (35b). In this example, the consequence of non-compliance would be being killed by the bear. Generally, *ḍe'* is used in urgent requests where non-compliance would result in very undesirable consequences.

It should be noted that this modified analysis of *ḍe'* as an urgency marker does not necessarily invalidate the claim that it mitigates a request, as put forward in Lovick (2016: 269). As Lovick (2016) notes, reiterating arguments also made by Scollon & Scollon (1981) or Rushforth & Chisholm (1991), uttering requests is considered to be interfering with another's freedom of action and thus undesirable in and of itself. Using *ḍe'* in a request draws attention to the undesirable consequences implicit in non-compliance, which in turn provides motivation for uttering the request in the first place – a form of mitigation.

Thus requests containing *ḍe'* serve the speaker's need to point to the necessity of compliance but crucially never spell out the possible consequences of non-compliance, trusting the addressee to be able to work this out for themselves.¹⁹ Spelling out the desirable consequences of compliance is not compatible with the Upper Tanana practice of speaking carefully about the future described in §1.1.

3.4 Beyond Upper Tanana

Similar constructions do not seem to be reported for related languages.

¹⁹This looks like the reversal of the indirect requests described by François (2026 [this volume]) for Mwotlap, where the undesirable consequence is spelled out, but no request is uttered.

4 Speaking carefully

In this section, I discuss several aspects of avertive linkings and urgent requests in greater detail, showing how they reflect general cultural patterns in Alaskan Dene: the keen awareness of which things are beyond an individual's control, and the need to be prepared for those things that are not (§4.1) as well as the principle of non-interference and respecting the competence of others (§4.2).

4.1 Control and preparedness

In §2.2, I showed that avertive linkings cannot be used in 'in-case' scenarios but only when the event in the avertive clause is actually under the control of the subject of the main clause. Speakers proved to be quite sensitive about this, consistently rejecting examples where control was absent or inadequate. As discussed in §2.3, there are several other constructions that can be used under these circumstances.

Yet, precisely because the Upper Tanana are aware of their limited control over their environment, they employ a circumspect mindset requiring them to be prepared for any eventuality. This had some surprising consequences for fieldwork. One of the examples of 'in-case' scenarios comes from a storyboard²⁰ (Vander Klok 2013); it is given in (36), repeated from (14) above.

- (36) *Eh Bill: Tay' t'eeey tah-chaan ay xah*
 and Bill again ADVZR 3SG.S:INC:AA.IPFV:H-rain:FUT:NMZ 3SG because
ch'ale u-shyii chq q taathüh di-dih-dlay
 FOC 3SG.PO-in umbrella QUAL-DH.PFV:1SG.S:Ø-keep.PL.O:IPFV:NMZ
tthiishyoh eh tl'aan dii na-ti-dhag-niign
 hat and and what PRMB-INC-DH.PFV:1SG.S:L-wear:IPFV:CUST:NMZ
tat'eeey u-shyii diih-dlah. (T)
 also 3SG.PO-in DH.PFV:1SG.S:Ø-keep.PL.O:IPFV
 'And Bill: It might rain again, that's why I keep the umbrella in [the
 backpack] and the hat and my clothes I also keep in it.'
 [UTCBAF13Nov1510:035]

Bill's behavior – he arrives at work wearing a coat, a hat, and carrying an umbrella on a fine day – may strike someone socialized in the mainstream American

²⁰Storyboards are sequences of images serving as stimulus for a speaker to tell the story in their own words. They allow the researcher to control the context of an utterance without having to use the contact language. For discussion of this methodology, see Burton & Matthewson (2015).

or Canadian worldview as ridiculous. Upper Tanana Dene, however, consider this perfectly sensible behavior due to the emphasis on *ts'edòònih* discussed in §1.1. Preparedness as that shown by Bill is valued and in fact encouraged as shown in (37), which is taken from a text about *ts'edòònih*:

- (37) a. *Nithaad dǎ' sh-nqq iin èh sh-tà' eh*
 long.time when:PST 1SG.PSR-mother PL and 1SG.PSR-father and
 “*Hah-'ógn elih tah hqqsú', hqqsú'*
 NTRL-outside:AR cold when well well
din-tl'qok hah'ógn ts'edòònih
 QUAL:Ø.IPFV:2SG.S:D-dress:IPFV:CUST NTRL-outside:AR never.know
xah,” nee-he-niik. (N)
 because 1PL.PO-3PL.S:Ø.IPFV:Ø-say:IPFV:CUST
 ‘A long time ago, our parents used to say to us, “When it is cold
 outside, dress (sg) well, because you never know.”’
 [UTOLAF19Jan0501:010]
- b. “*Elók hq-q-tij nij-thänh dè'*
 hot AR.S:Ø.PFV:Ø-be:IPFV QUAL:Ø.PFV:2SG.S:Ø-think:IPFV if
n-ch'il' tij-leek.” (N)
 2SG.PSR-clothes:POSS INC:Ø.IPFV:2SG.S:Ø-handle.PL.O:IPFV:CUST
 “Even if you (sg) think it is hot, take your (sg) clothes.”’
 [UTOLAF19Jan0501:011]
- c. *N-èh n-èh tij-leek*
 2SG.PO-with 2SG.PO-with INC:Ø.IPFV:2SG.S:Ø-handle.PL.O:IPFV:CUST
nah-'ógn nts'qǎ' u-taa-nǐl nts'qǎ'
 MED-outside:AR ADVZR AR.S-INC:AA.IPFV:Ø-happen:FUT ADVZR
hi-ts'-in-nígn xah. (N)
 PP-PEJ-Ø.PFV:2SG.S:D-not.know:IPFV because
 “Take them with you because you don’t know what will happen out
 there.”’
 [UTOLAF19Jan0501:012]

In a way, the cultural emphasis on preparedness could be considered one reason for the rarity of avertive linkings in the narrative corpus.

4.2 Respecting the competence of others

Looking at the distribution of avertive linkings and urgent requests by genre (Table 3), it becomes apparent that they are used with very different audiences.

Table 3: Avertive linkings and urgent requests by genre

	avertive	urgent requests
past events	12	44
teachings	6	3
total	18	47

“Past events” includes the three narrative genres of old-time stories, histories, and personal narratives identified in Lovick (2012). As pointed out by Jones & Thompson (1990: ix) in the context of old-time stories, these stories are told “to entertain, educate and inspire – to cause the reader or listener to think” (see also Bergelson (2019) on lessons implicit in personal narratives). The typical audience for this type of narrative is composed of community members. Crucially, the lessons contained in these stories are expressed implicitly and require the audience to unpack them, using the cultural knowledge at their disposal. “Teachings” refers to a non-traditional genre where speakers explain cultural knowledge to an audience consisting of community outsiders such as linguists and anthropologists, or to young people who did not grow up in the traditional way. The explanations in such texts are very explicit and often contain rationales for the ritualistic acts discussed in §1.1. It is thus not surprising that a third of all examples of avertive linkings come from teachings: these are explanations of cultural practices aimed at those who are unfamiliar with them ((6a)–(6b) fall into that category). It is also not surprising that there are so few urgent requests in these texts: leaving aside the relative rarity of non-declaratives in this text type, speakers are also cognizant of the fact that the audience of a “teaching” text may not be able to interpret the request correctly. Instead, urgent requests occur predominantly in stories where characters well-versed in Upper Tanana culture interact with one another (see Lovick (2016) for a discussion of using stories for the investigation of requests). The traditional audience for these texts does need to be told the consequences of (non-)compliance. Explicitly stating the (desirable) outcome of compliance with the urgent request would be a violation of the practice of careful speaking. Stating the (undesirable) consequence of non-compliance, on the other hand, could suggest that the addressee is not able to think for themselves or “does not know their *ijjih*”, which is not compatible with the principle of non-interference and respect. In either case, verbalizing the potential consequences in an urgent request would collide with fundamental principles of Upper Tanana culture.

Together, avertive linkings and requests with *dè'* fulfill an Upper Tanana speaker's need to remind the addressee of circumspect action, while at the same time treating them as a competent person who "knows their *ijjih*".

5 Conclusion

In this paper, I described avertive linkings and urgent requests in Upper Tanana Dene, and discussed how they reflect the circumspect mindset of Upper Tanana people.

Avertive linkings are a type of adverbial linking involving the subordinator *ch'à'* 'AVERT, lest'. The avertive clause is usually in the future, more rarely in the inceptive perfective mode. It is always formally affirmative. The main clause has no mode restrictions and also has to be formally affirmative. There are no other formal restrictions on avertive linkings. Semantically, avertive linkings are limited to situations where an undesirable consequence (expressed in the avertive clause) can be avoided by taking the preemptive action expressed in the main clause. This linking is very sensitive to the notion of what can and cannot be controlled by human action and thus cannot be used in 'in-case' scenarios. It also cannot be used in linkings where the main predicate is one of fear.

Somewhat unusually typologically, avertive linkings with a request as main clause are rare in Upper Tanana. I argue in this paper that this is likely due to the fact that requests are problematic in Northern Dene in general, and that spelling out the undesirable consequences to be avoided could suggest to the hearer that they are thought to be lacking in cultural knowledge. Instead, there is a dedicated strategy for urgent requests formed using the particle *dè'*. This type of request likely has arisen as a insubordinate conditional structure. The undesirable consequence of non-compliance is implicated, but never spelled out.

The existence and usage patterns of these constructions reflect the circumspect mindset of the Upper Tanana people, i.e., the need to act and speak mindfully. Avertive linkings spell out the undesirable consequences that can be avoided by taking the action in the main clause. They occur primarily in texts directed at community outsiders who often are unaware of the many, often ritualistic, actions performed to ensure a favorable outcome. Requests formed with *dè'* point to the existence of undesirable consequences, but crucially never spell these out: the speaker assumes that the hearer has the required cultural knowledge to do so. Thus, such requests usually are directed towards a member of the community, who can be relied on to have this knowledge. In this fashion, avertive linkings and requests with *dè'* complement each other in the domain of circumspection, while respecting the addressee's cultural competence.

Abbreviations

AA	<i>aa</i> -conjugation	N	<i>n</i> -conjugation
ABL	ablative	NMZ	nominalizer
ADVZR	adverbializer	NEG	negative
ALL	allative	NTRL	neutral distance
AR	areal	O	direct object
AVERT	avertive	OPT	optative
B	Beaver Creek dialect	PO	postpositional object
COMP	complementizer	PEJ	pejorative
CO	compact object	PFV	perfective
CONT	continuative	PL	plural
CT	contrastive topic	POSS	possessed
CUST	customary	PP	postposition
D	D-voice/valence maker	PRMB	perambulative
DH	<i>dh</i> -conjugation	PROG	progressive
FOC	focus	PROH	prohibitive
FUT	future	PSR	possessor
H	H-voice/valence marker	PURP	purposive
IMP	imperative	QUAL	qualifier
IPFV	imperfective	RECP	reciprocal
INC	inceptive	REFL	reflexive
INDF	indefinite	S	Scottie Creek dialect
IT	iterative	S	subject
L	L-voice/valence marker	SG	singular
LEX	lexical morpheme	T	Tetlin dialect
LRO	long rigid object	TERM	terminative
MED	medial distance	UR	urgent request
N	Northway dialect		

Acknowledgements

I want to express my deep gratitude to all of the Upper Tanana speakers who so patiently teach me about their language and their culture. From Northway: Mr. Roy Sam and Mrs. Avis Sam as well as Mrs. Sherry Demit Barnes. From Tetlin: Mr. Roy H. David, Sr., and Mrs. Ida Joe. *Tsinah'ij* for your hard work, and for all the laughter.

Marsi choh! also goes to the Doyon Languages Online project led by Allan Hayton and to Jim Kari and the College of Rural and Cross-Cultural Studies at

the University of Alaska Fairbanks for funding my plane fare to Alaska in 2018 and 2019, thus facilitating my visits to the Upper Tanana area.

Baasee’ to David Engles for discussing these topics with me during our trip to the airport and to Siri Tuttle for providing comments on an earlier draft of this paper. *Marci cho* to Dagmar Jung for the Dëne Sųliné example. *Merci* to the participants in the workshop ‘Lest we miss them’ at the at the VIII Syntax of the World’s Languages conference, September 3–5, 2018, in Paris, France for their comments and questions. *Thank you* to two anonymous reviewers and to the editors, whose comments and questions benefitted the paper considerably.

While I could not have written this paper without the individuals named above, all errors of fact, representation, or interpretation are my own.

References

- Anisman, Adar. 2019. *When if is when and when is then: The particle nįdè in Tłįchų*. University of Victoria. (Doctoral dissertation). <http://hdl.handle.net/1828/11356>.
- Basso, Keith H. 1979. *Portraits of the “Whiteman”: Linguistic play and cultural symbols among the Western Apache*. Cambridge: Cambridge University Press.
- Basso, Keith H. 1990. ‘To give up on words’: Silence in Western Apache culture. In *Western Apache language and culture: Essays in linguistic anthropology*. Tucson: The University of Arizona Press. 80–98. DOI: 10.2307/j.ctv1h7zms9.10.
- Bergelson, Mira. 2019. Maintaining tradition: Thematic and structural coherence in personal stories by Northern Athabaskans. *Anthropological Linguistics* 61(2). 183–219.
- Burton, Strang & Lisa Matthewson. 2015. Targeted construction storyboards in semantic fieldwork. In M. Ryan Bochnak & Lisa Matthewson (eds.), *Methodologies in semantic fieldwork*, 135–157. Oxford: Oxford University Press.
- Cook, Eung-Do. 2004. *A grammar of Dëne Sųliné (Chipewyan)* (Algonquian and Iroquoian Linguistics memoirs, Vol. 17). Winnipeg: University of Manitoba.
- Dixon, R. M. W. 2009. The semantics of clause-linking in typological perspective. In R. M. W. Dixon & Alexandra Y. Aikhenvald (eds.), *The semantics of clause-linking: A cross-linguistic typology*, 1–55. Oxford: Oxford University Press.
- Evans, Nicholas. 2007. Insubordination and its uses. In Irina Nikolaeva (ed.), *Finiteness: Theoretical and empirical foundations*, 366–431. Oxford: Oxford University Press.

- François, Alexandre. 2026. Explicit apprehensions, implicit instructions: An indirect speech act in the grammar. In Martina Faller, Marine Vuillermet & Eva Schultze-Berndt (eds.), *Apprehensional constructions in a cross-linguistic perspective*, 423–460. Berlin: Language Science Press. DOI: 10.5281/zenodo.19708147.
- Guéron, Marie-Françoise. 1974. *People of Tetlin why are you singing?* (Mercury Series, Ethnology Division). Ottawa: National Museum of Man, National Museums of Canada.
- Guéron, Marie-Françoise. 1981. Upper Tanana river potlatch. In June Helm (ed.), *Handbook of North American Indians*, vol. 6: *Subarctic*. Washington: Smithsonian Institution.
- Guéron, Marie-Françoise. 2005. *Le rêve et la forêt [The dream and the forest]*. Québec: Les Presses de l'Université Laval.
- Hargus, Sharon, Olga Lovick & Siri G. Tuttle. 2020. Glossing Dene languages. In Kayla Begay & Kayla Palakurthy (eds.), *Proceedings of the 2019 Dene Languages conference, Alaska Native Language Center Working Papers Number 16*, 12–64. Fairbanks: Alaska Native Language Center.
- Jones, Eliza & Chad Thompson. 1990. Introduction. In Eliza Jones & Chad Thompson (eds.), *K'etetaalkkaanee, the one who paddled among the people and animals: The story of an ancient traveler. Told by Catherine Attla*, viii–xii. Fairbanks: Alaska Native Language Center.
- Kalifornsky, Peter. 1991. *A Dena'ina legacy – K'tl'eghi sukdu: The collected writings of Peter Kalifornsky. Edited by James Kari and Alan Boraas*. Fairbanks: Alaska Native Language Center.
- Kari, James (ed.). 1986. *Tatl'ahwt'aenn nenn': The Headwaters People's country. Narratives of the Upper Ahtna Athabaskans*. Fairbanks: Alaska Native Language Center.
- Kari, James. 1993. Diversity in morpheme order in several Alaskan Athabaskan languages: Notes on the *gh*-qualifier. *Proceedings of the Nineteenth Annual Meeting of the Berkeley Linguistics Society: Special Session on Syntactic Issues in Native American Languages* 19(2). 50–56.
- Kari, James. 1997. *Upper Tanana stem list, with additions by Olga Lovick*. Unpublished Lexware file.
- Krauss, Michael E. 2000. Koyukon dialectology and its relationship to other Athabaskan languages. In Jules Jetté & Eliza Jones (eds.), *Koyukon Athabaskan dictionary*, 1–lxv. Fairbanks: Alaska Native Language Center.
- Krauss, Michael E. 2005. Athabaskan tone. In Keren Rice & Sharon Hargus (eds.), *Athabaskan prosody*, 51–136. Amsterdam: John Benjamins.

- Leer, Jeff. 1979. *Proto-Athabaskan verb stem variation part one: Phonology* (Alaska Native Language Center Research Papers, Number 1). Fairbanks: Alaska Native Language Center.
- Leer, Jeff. 1996. *Comparative Athabaskan lexicon*. Ms. no. CA965L1996a. Alaska Native Language Archive. <https://www.uaf.edu/anla/record.php?identifier=CA965L1996a>.
- Lichtenberk, František. 1995. Apprehensional epistemics. In Joan L. Bybee & Suzanne Fleischman (eds.), *Modality in grammar and discourse*, 293–327. Amsterdam: John Benjamins. DOI: 10.1075/tsl.32.12lic.
- Lovick, Olga. 2012. The identification of narrative genres in Upper Tanana Athabaskan: A preliminary study. *Northwest Journal of Linguistics* 6(3). 1–29.
- Lovick, Olga. 2016. *Ijijih* and request formation in Upper Tanana Athabaskan: Evidence from narrative text. *Anthropological Linguistics* 58(3). 248–298.
- Lovick, Olga. 2017. *Functions of the ‘future’ and ‘optative’ in Upper Tanana Athabaskan*. Paper presented at the 2017 Annual Meeting of the Society for the Study of the Indigenous Languages of the Americas, held January 5–8, in Austin, Texas.
- Lovick, Olga. 2020a. *A grammar of Upper Tanana, vol. 1: Phonology, lexical categories, morphology*. Lincoln: University of Nebraska Press.
- Lovick, Olga. 2020b. Existential and standard negation in Northern Dene. *International Journal of American Linguistics* 86(4). 485–525.
- Lovick, Olga. 2023. *A grammar of Upper Tanana, vol. 2: Semantics, syntax, discourse*. Lincoln: University of Nebraska Press.
- Lovick, Olga & Siri G. Tuttle. 2019. Video elicitation of negative directives in Alaskan Dene languages: Reflections on methodology. In Aimée Lahaussais & Marine Vuillermet (eds.), *Methodological tools for linguistic description and typology* (Language Documentation & Conservation Special Publication No. 16), 125–154. Honolulu: University of Hawai’i Press.
- McKenna, Robert A. 1959. *The Upper Tanana Indians* (Yale University Publications in Anthropology). New Haven: Department of Anthropology, Yale University.
- McKenna, Robert A. 1969. Athapaskan groups of central Alaska at the time of white contact. *Ethnohistory* 16(4). 335–343.
- McKenna, Robert A. 1981. Tanana. In June Helm (ed.), *Handbook of North American Indians, volume 6: Subarctic*, 562–576. Washington: Smithsonian Institution.
- Minoura, Nobukatsu. 1994. A comparative phonology of the Upper Tanana Athabaskan dialects. In Osahito Miyaoka (ed.), *Languages of the North Pacific Rim*

- (Hokkaido University Publications in Linguistics Number). Sapporo: Department of Linguistics, Faculty of Letters, Hokkaido University.
- Nelson, Richard K. 1973. *Hunters of the Northern Forest*. Chicago: Chicago University Press.
- Nelson, Richard K. 1983. *Make prayers to the raven: A Koyukon view of the boreal forest*. Chicago: Chicago University Press.
- Nelson, Richard K., Kathleen H. Mautner & G. Ray Bane. 1982. *Tracks in the wildland: A portrayal of Koyukon and Nunamiut subsistence*. Fairbanks: Anthropology & Historic Preservation Cooperative Park Studies Unit, University of Alaska Fairbanks.
- Rice, Keren. 1989. *A grammar of Slave*. Berlin: Mouton de Gruyter.
- Rushforth, Scott. 1985. Some directive illocutionary acts among the Bearlake Athapaskans. *Anthropological Linguistics* 27(4). 384–411.
- Rushforth, Scott & James S. Chisholm. 1991. *Cultural persistence: Continuity in meaning and moral responsibility among the Bearlake Athapaskans*. Tucson & London: The University of Arizona Press.
- Scollon, Ronald & Suzanne B. K. Scollon. 1981. *Narrative, literacy, and face in interethnic communication*. Norwood: Ablex Publishing Corporation.
- Simeone, William E. 1995. *Rifles, blankets and beads: Identity, history, and the Northern Athapaskan potlatch*. Norman: University of Oklahoma Press.
- Tyone, Mary. 1996. *Ttheek'ādn Ut'iin yaaniidq' qōnign': Old time stories of the Scottie Creek People. Stories told in Upper Tanana Athabaskan by Mary Tyone, Ts'q' Yahnik*. Fairbanks: Alaska Native Language Center.
- Vander Klok, Jozina. 2013. *Bill vs. the weather*. Totem Field Storyboards. <https://totemfieldstoryboards.org> (18 March, 2025).
- van Gelderen, Elly. 2008. Cycles of negation in Athabaskan. In Siri Tuttle (ed.), *Working Papers in Athabaskan linguistics 2007*, 49–64. Fairbanks: Alaska Native Language Center.
- Vuillermet, Marine. 2018. Questionnaire on the apprehensional domain (v2). Unpublished ms. Laboratoire Dynamique Du Langage, Lyon. <http://tulquest.huma-num.fr/fr/node/135>.
- Wiemer, Björn. 2026. Two major apprehensional strategies in Slavic: A survey of their areal and grammatical distribution. In Martina Faller, Marine Vuillermet & Eva Schultze-Berndt (eds.), *Apprehensional constructions in a cross-linguistic perspective*, 231–285. Berlin: Language Science Press. DOI: 10.5281/zenodo.19708135.

